

7. Education and Literacy

The data on education and literacy collected during a population census is vital for a country's human resource development and the formulation of future policies. In the Census of Population and Housing - 2024, information was collected for all persons aged three years and over on the educational activities in which they were engaged during the census reference period (defined as the 30 days preceding the date of enumeration) as well as on the highest level of educational attainment obtained at the time of the census. Based on these data, the government and relevant authorities are empowered to facilitate evidence-based decision-making in education, including the allocation of resources and the mitigation of educational disparities, as well as the formulation of new educational policies. Furthermore, information was collected on literacy in the main languages used in Sri Lanka "Sinhala," "Tamil," and "English" as well as on educational level, computer and digital literacy.

Education

In Sri Lanka, eligibility for admission to Grade 1 within the Government education system requires a child to have completed five years of age by the commencement of the relevant academic year. In government schools, the academic year generally extends from January to December. Admission to Grade 1 in private and international schools is also subject to the requirement that the child has completed five years of age. However, the academic calendars of private and international schools may differ from the academic year followed by government schools.

Educational activities during the reference period

Information on educational activities undertaken during the 30 days preceding the census enumeration date was collected from all persons aged three years and over. Accordingly, the specific educational activity in which an individual was engaged during the reference period was identified, and persons who were not engaged in any educational activity during that period were also distinguished. Furthermore, it should be noted that the 2024 Census period fell towards the latter part of the year, which directly impacted these statistics.

Table 7.1 : Population Aged 3 Years and Over by Sex and Educational Activity During the Census Reference Period, 2024

Educational activity	Population aged 03 years and over					
	Total	%	Male	%	Female	%
Total	21,134,659	100.0	10,187,314	100.0	10,947,345	100.0
Preschool education	482,106	2.3	243,648	2.4	238,458	2.2
School education	4,351,225	20.6	2,157,831	21.2	2,193,394	20.0
Degree/Postgraduate education	320,989	1.5	120,745	1.2	200,244	1.8
Vocational training/Technical education	122,457	0.6	70,149	0.7	52,308	0.5
Other educational activity	266,413	1.3	125,671	1.2	140,742	1.3
Not studying	15,591,469	73.7	7,469,270	73.3	8,122,199	74.2

Table 7.1 presents the distribution of the population aged three years and over according to their involvement in educational activities during the reference period, by sex. Approximately one-fourth of the population (26.2%) was engaged in some form of educational activity. Further, of the population 482,106 (2.3%) were attending pre-school, 4,351,225 (20.6%) were attending in school education, 320,989 (1.5%) were engaged in graduate or post-graduate studies, 0.6 percent were following vocational or technical education, and 1.3 percent were involved in other forms of education. Meanwhile, 73.7 percent of aged 3 years and over were not engaged in any educational activity during the reference period.